Name: _____ **Date:** _____

Exploring Mood

Mood is the feeling you get from reading a piece of writing. Another way to describe mood is *atmosphere*. When you walk into a place, it has an atmosphere that makes you feel a certain way; when you "walk into" a story, it too has an atmosphere that creates a feeling. Writers create mood through word choice, imagery, dialogue, setting, and plot.

In this activity, you will consider the mood of a passage from "Disaster in Space" by Lauren Tarshis. Here is the passage, which is from page 6 in the section "A Mission to the Moon":

> Two days earlier, Apollo 13 had blasted off from Florida's Kennedy Space Center. Lovell, Haise, and Swigert were strapped inside their small spacecraft, which was perched atop a 360-foot-tall rocket packed with millions of pounds of explosive fuel.
>
> *Five, four, three, two, one . . .*
>
> With a deafening roar and a brilliant flare of fiery gas, the rocket catapulted Apollo 13 into the sky. It streaked through the air at 24,000 miles per hour—14 times the speed of a bullet. The force strained the astronauts' hearts. It stretched back the skin on their faces until it seemed the skin would rip away from their skulls. The men felt as though their bones might shatter.
>
> But this was all normal. In fact, the launch was just about perfect.
>
> Soon the astronauts had left Earth and were cruising toward their destination. Their mission was to land on the moon and explore a hilly section called Fra Mauro. They were to gather samples of the moon's sandy dirt and 4-billion-year-old rocks.
>
> First, though, the astronauts had to get there.

Here are two words that could be used to describe the mood of the passage:

intense, dangerous

Now let's look at what creates this mood.

The Situation

One thing that makes the mood intense and dangerous is the situation—in other words, what happens.

1. In 1-2 sentences, summarize what Tarshis describes in the passage above.

_____

_____

_____

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Descriptive Details

It's not just the situation that gives the passage an intense, dangerous mood. The way Tarshis brings the situation to life also helps to create the mood. Let's take a look at some of her descriptive details.

2. Sentences: "Lovell, Haise, and Swigert were strapped inside their small spacecraft, which was perched atop a 360-foot-tall rocket packed with millions of pounds of explosive fuel. *Five, four, three, two, one. . .*"

Below are two ways that the sentences above create a feeling of intensity and danger. Complete the sentence in (C) to explain a third way.

A. When Tarshis describes "a small spacecraft, perched atop the 360-foot-tall rocket," she creates an image of the spacecraft as tiny and fragile. It doesn't sound like the astronauts are well-protected from the powerful rocket below them.

B. The liftoff countdown ("*Five, four, three, two, one . . .*") draws out the moments before the ship blasts off. This creates suspense and tension, which increases the intensity and the feeling of danger.

C. When Tarshis describes the rocket as being "packed with millions of pounds of explosive fuel,"readers understand _____

_____

3. Sentence: "With a deafening roar and a brilliant flare of fiery gas, the rocket catapulted Apollo 13 into the sky."

Look at all the descriptive adjectives, verbs, and nouns in that sentence! Below is one way that Tarshis's words create a feeling of intensity and danger. Write one more way.

A. When Tarshis writes "with a deafening roar," the reader can imagine how intense the sound was as the ship lifted off.

B. _____

_____

4. Sentence: "It stretched back the skin on their faces until it seemed the skin would rip away from their skulls."

Write one way this sentence helps create an intense and dangerous mood.

_____

_____

_____

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5. Find one more sentence from anywhere in the passage that helps create a mood of intensity and/or danger. Write it in the space provided. Then write two ways it helps create a mood of intensity and/or danger.

Sentence: _____

_____

How this sentence helps create a mood of intensity and/or danger:

A. _____

_____

_____

B. _____

_____

_____

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